

A Workbook. Not a Wellness Book.

WHAT NOBODY TELLS YOU ABOUT GETTING OLD

MARS KOWALSKI'S BLUNT WORKBOOK

Eight conversations you should have before it's too late.

"I've seen what happens when you don't listen. Don't be a statistic."

BY MARLENE "MARS" KOWALSKI

58, RETIRED ICU NURSE OF 22 YEARS

A FICTIONAL CHARACTER, CREATED WITH AI

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A LETTER FROM MARS

I want to get one thing out of the way before you turn the page. Whatever you're avoiding about getting older, you are not the only one avoiding it, and you are not doing a worse job than anyone else. Everybody thinks their own denial is the special kind. It isn't.

I spent twenty-two years watching people arrive at the worst version of a conversation they'd been putting off for a decade. Not because they were bad people. Because putting it off felt like the safer choice, right up until it wasn't.

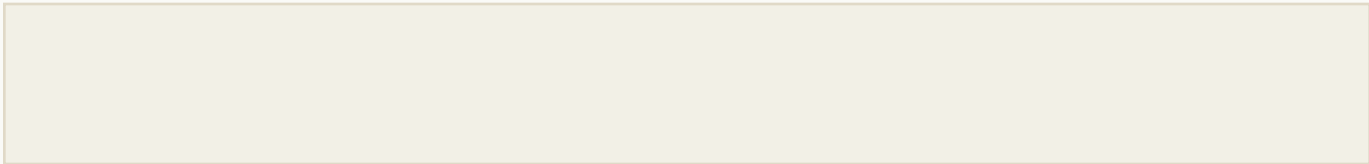
This isn't a wellness book. I'm not going to tell you to drink more water and call it a plan for aging well, though you should probably drink more water. This is the stuff I actually watched matter. Who you call. What paper you sign. What you say out loud before you can't.

You bought this because you wanted the version without the spa music. Good. Here it is.

Mars

ABOUT MARS

Mars Kowalski is a fictional character, and this workbook was created with the help of AI. She is not a real nurse, and the patients and families she describes are invented composites. Nothing in this workbook is medical, legal or financial advice.



THE FOUNDATION

Why This Works

Here's the honest mechanism, no dressing it up. Most people don't fail at aging well because they lack information. You already know you should have a will. You already know you should call your sister back. The failure point isn't knowledge. It's that none of it feels urgent until it's an emergency, and emergencies are terrible teachers, because by then your choices are gone.

Research on aging keeps pointing at the same handful of things: a small, reliable circle of contact, and staying attached to something that gives the day a reason. Studies of advance care planning also suggest that people whose wishes are written down are more likely to get the care they actually wanted. None of that is glamorous. None of it fits on a supplement label.

WHAT TO EXPECT

Page 8 is going to annoy you. That's the money one. Everybody wants to skip it or argue with it in their head. Do it anyway.

You might also find the paperwork page and the last conversation page harder to sit with than the rest. That's normal, and it's not a sign you're doing this wrong. It's a sign those are the two things you've been avoiding the longest.

THE RULE ABOUT FALLING BEHIND

If you put this down for three weeks, you have not failed anything. There's no streak to lose here. This isn't a fitness app. The rule: no restarts, no catching up, no doing four pages in one sitting to make up for lost time.

Just open it back up to wherever you left off and do the next one. This workbook is a record of what you've worked through, not a courtroom deciding whether you did it fast enough.

BASELINE

Where You Stand

Before you read another page, score yourself honestly. Nobody's grading this but you, and you'll score it again at the back of the book.

How prepared do I actually feel for getting older?

/ 10

How connected am I to the people who'd actually show up?

/ 10

How honest have I been with myself about what I need?

/ 10

ONE LINE TO THE YOU WHO FINISHES THIS WORKBOOK:

MAKE IT FIT YOUR LIFE

If you're doing this for a parent, not yourself: read every page as a conversation starter, not a checklist to hand them. Nobody wants their kid showing up with a workbook about their death.

If you're recently widowed: several pages assume you have a person to call. If you don't right now, that's page 6's whole point. Start there.

If you're estranged from family: the two people on your nightstand list don't have to be blood. They have to be reliable.

If something here feels bigger than a workbook: that's what page 15 is for. Reaching out for help isn't the failure. It's the strong move.

The Nightstand Rule

I lost count of how many people came into my unit because they fell in their own kitchen at two in the morning and lay there for hours before anyone found them. Not because they were frail. Because they were proud, and proud people don't call for help until they're already on the floor.

Here's the rule. Tonight, before you need it: a charged phone within arm's reach of your bed, a flashlight next to it, and two people's names written on paper, not just saved in a phone that might die right next to you. And if you live alone, the phone comes with you around the house in the daytime, because a phone on the nightstand can't help you on the kitchen floor.

That's it. Not a brochure for a place with a courtyard. A phone, a light, a name. If a medical alert device would give you or your family real peace of mind, get one as well; it's a tool, not a defeat. You don't lose your independence by planning for the bad night. You lose it by pretending the bad night isn't coming.

WHAT ACTUALLY MATTERS

- ☐ A charged phone within arm's reach of the bed every night, and on you during the day if you live alone.
- ☐ Two people's numbers written on paper, not just saved in a phone.
- ☐ One person who knows to check in if they don't hear from you by a set time.

WRITE IT DOWN:

Who are your two people, and do they actually know they're your two people?

The One Phone Call Rule

I had a patient whose emergency contact card had four numbers on it. All four were disconnected. Not because anyone died. Because nobody had updated a phone number in six years, and by the time it mattered, no one knew who to call.

The rule: pick two people. Call them this week, not to tell them anything urgent, just to make sure the number still works and they know they're on your list.

Reconnecting after a decade of silence is a much harder call to make in an emergency room waiting area than it is on a random Tuesday. You don't get to find out your safety net has holes in it during the fall. Check it now.

WHAT ACTUALLY MATTERS

- ☐ Two current phone numbers, tested, not assumed.
- ☐ Both people told plainly that they're your two people.
- ☐ At least one of them close enough to actually show up, not just call.

WRITE IT DOWN:

Who are you calling this week, and what will you say?

The Paperwork Isn't Morbid Rule

I've seen families stand in a hallway arguing about what their mother would have wanted, because she never wrote it down and everyone remembered a different conversation. That argument doesn't happen when there's a piece of paper.

The three documents that actually matter: a healthcare directive, so someone knows who decides if you can't; a power of attorney, so someone can handle the practical stuff; and a will, so there's no guessing about who gets what. What these are called, and how they work, varies by state and country, so a local legal aid clinic or lawyer can tell you what yours look like.

None of them require you to expect the worst next week. They just mean the worst week, whenever it comes, isn't also a fight. Writing it down isn't inviting death in. It's telling the people you love what to do instead of guessing.

WHAT ACTUALLY MATTERS

- ☐ A named healthcare decision maker, in writing.
- ☐ A power of attorney and a basic will, even simple ones (use a low-cost or free legal clinic if needed).
- ☐ The documents told to the people who'd need them, not just filed in a drawer.

WRITE IT DOWN:

Which of these three do you actually have done right now?

The Casserole Rule

There's a particular kind of family I used to see. Someone dies or gets sick, and within a week there's a casserole in every fridge and nobody knows where the bank accounts are. The food shows up. The paperwork doesn't.

This isn't about having more money. It's about someone besides you knowing where the money is. One page, one list: what accounts exist, roughly what's owed on what, and who to call about each one. Update it once a year. Leave passwords and full account numbers off the page; the list says where things are and who to call, not how to get in.

I'm not going to tell you what to invest in or how to grow it. That's not my lane and it's not this workbook's job. What I will tell you is that a list somebody else can find beats a system only you understand.

WHAT ACTUALLY MATTERS

- ☐ A written list of accounts and who to contact for each.
- ☐ That list stored somewhere someone else can actually find it.
- ☐ One honest conversation with whoever would inherit the mess about where that list lives.

WRITE IT DOWN:

If something happened to me this week, who would know where to start?

The Body You Actually Have

I've watched people in their seventies recover from surgery faster than people in their fifties, and in my experience the difference wasn't luck. It was that the seventy-year-old had kept walking every single day for thirty years, and the fifty-year-old hadn't moved much since a desk job started.

You don't need a program. You need to not stop moving. Walking counts. Gardening counts. Carrying your own groceries counts. The goal isn't a number on a scale, it's still being able to get off the floor by yourself in twenty years.

For anything specific to your own health, that's a conversation for your actual doctor, not a workbook. Nobody's coming to save your knees for you. Use them or lose the use of them.

WHAT ACTUALLY MATTERS

- ☐ Some form of daily movement that's safe for your body and isn't optional in your head.
- ☐ A real conversation with your doctor about what your body specifically needs.
- ☐ One physical thing you'd genuinely miss being unable to do, named honestly.

WRITE IT DOWN:

What's the one physical thing I refuse to lose the ability to do?

The Empty Chair Rule

The hardest part of getting older that nobody warns you about isn't your own body. It's watching the chairs around the table empty out one at a time. I've sat with people who stopped making new friends at sixty because it felt disloyal to the ones they'd lost. Then they had nobody left in the room.

Grief for the people you've lost is real and it deserves its own space, not a bullet point in a workbook. But staying in the room, making room for new people even while missing the old ones, isn't a betrayal. It's how you don't end up alone in a chair with nobody sitting in the others.

The table doesn't have to stay set for people who are gone. Set a place for someone new.

WHAT ACTUALLY MATTERS

- ☐ One new relationship or reconnection actively kept up, not just wished for.
- ☐ Somewhere you show up regularly enough that people would notice if you stopped.
- ☐ Honesty with yourself about whether grief has quietly become isolation.

WRITE IT DOWN:

Where could I show up regularly that I've been avoiding?

The Purpose Isn't Optional

I've seen people retire on a Friday and turn up in my unit not long after, and I couldn't always say their heart gave out first. What I noticed was that Monday morning had stopped meaning anything, and their body seemed to notice before their mind admitted it. I can't prove that. I'm a nurse, not a researcher. But I saw it often enough to put it in a workbook.

You don't need a job to have a reason to get up. You need something that needs you: a grandchild, a garden, a volunteer shift, a project with a deadline.

Retirement from work doesn't have to mean retirement from being needed. A calendar with nothing on it isn't rest. It's a slow leak.

WHAT ACTUALLY MATTERS

- ☐ One thing on the calendar this week that only you can do.
- ☐ Someone or something that would notice if you didn't show up.
- ☐ An honest answer to what a fully empty Tuesday would look like, and whether that scares you.

WRITE IT DOWN:

What needs me right now that I've been putting off?

The Last Conversation Rule

I've held hands with people saying things to their families for the first time in a hospital bed that should have been said fifteen years earlier, at a kitchen table, with time to actually mean it.

You don't have to wait for a diagnosis to say the things that matter, or to ask the questions you're avoiding. What do they want if things get bad. What are they proud of. What do they regret.

These conversations get easier the earlier you have them and almost impossible the later you wait. Nobody ever told me they regretted having that conversation too early. Plenty told me they wished they'd had it at all.

WHAT ACTUALLY MATTERS

- ☐ One conversation about end of life wishes, had out loud, not assumed.
- ☐ One thing said to someone you love that you've been saving for someday.
- ☐ A plan for who's told what, so nobody finds out from a stranger.

WRITE IT DOWN:

What's the conversation I've been putting off, and with who?

THE WORKING PAGES

The Master Checklist

The whole workbook, one page. Keep this one out.

NIGHTSTAND	Phone, flashlight, two names, within arm's reach at night, on you by day if you live alone.
PHONE CALL	Two people, current numbers, both told they're the two.
PAPERWORK	Healthcare directive, power of attorney, will. Written, not assumed.
CASSEROLE	A written list of accounts and who to call, stored where it can be found.
BODY	Moving most days, in whatever way is safe for you. And a real doctor for the specifics.
EMPTY CHAIR	One relationship actively kept up, one place you're regularly seen.
PURPOSE	One thing on the calendar this week that only you can do.
CONVERSATION	End of life wishes said out loud, not assumed.

QUICKSTART: FIVE THINGS FOR THIS WEEK

For the person who isn't doing the whole workbook right now. Do these five things.

1. Put a charged phone and a flashlight within arm's reach of your bed, tonight.
2. Call one person on your list this week, just to check the line still works.
3. Find out if you have a healthcare directive. Ask your doctor's office about the form.
4. Write down where your accounts are, and tell one person where the paper lives.
5. Say one true thing out loud to someone you love that you've been saving.

APPENDIX

Bonus Materials

THE PAPERWORK LIST (ANNOTATED)

This is organizational, not legal advice. Names and rules vary by state and country. Legal aid and elder law clinics can often help for free or low cost.

Healthcare directive: Who decides medical care if you can't. Ask your doctor's office.

Power of attorney (financial): Who can handle bills and accounts if you're unable to.

A basic will: Who gets what. Legal aid clinics often do simple wills at low or no cost.

Beneficiary designations: Check accounts actually match who you want, not who was listed decades ago.

Account list: Every account and who to contact, in one place, updated yearly. No passwords.

Document location: Where all of the above physically live, told to the person who'd need them.

Copies given: At least one trusted person has copies or knows exactly where to find them.

THE ONE PHONE CALL SCRIPTS

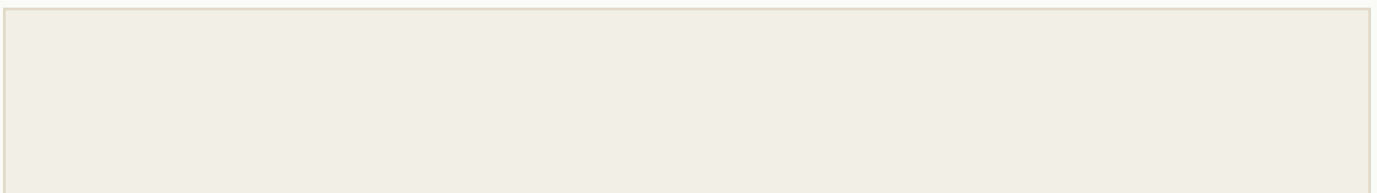
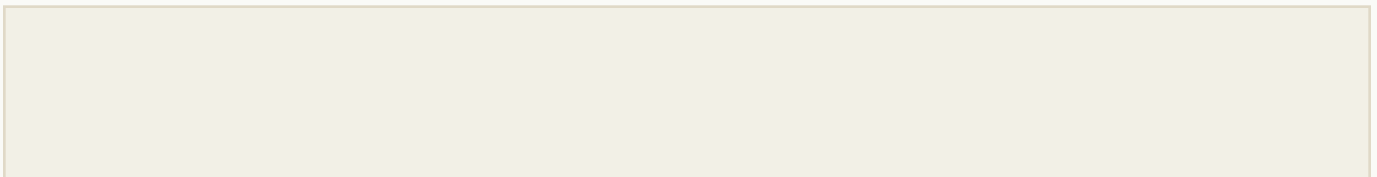
No script makes someone want to talk to you who genuinely doesn't. These are just openers to get past the hardest part: dialing.

SCRIPT 1: RECONNECTING AFTER A WHILE

"Hey, it's me. I know it's been a while and there's no big reason for the call, I just realized I hadn't checked in and wanted to fix that. How have you been?"

SCRIPT 2: RECONNECTING AFTER DISTANCE OR HURT

"I've been thinking about you and I wanted to reach out. No pressure, no big conversation needed right now. I just didn't want too much more time to pass."



REFLECTION

Where You Stand Now

Score yourself again, honestly. Then compare it to where you started on page 4.

How prepared do I actually feel for getting older?

/ 10

How connected am I to the people who'd actually show up?

/ 10

How honest have I been with myself about what I need?

/ 10

KEEP THREE:

The three rules from this workbook that actually changed something. Write them below. Those three are yours now, permanently.

The Honest Small Print

Mars Kowalski is a fictional character, and this workbook was created with the help of AI. Her nursing career, patients and stories are invented composites, not real people or real medical records. Nothing in it is medical, legal or financial advice, and the documents and rules it describes are general and US-oriented; they vary by state and country.

For your specific health, talk to your doctor. For your specific legal documents, talk to a lawyer or a local legal aid clinic. For your specific money, talk to a licensed financial professional.

If anything in this workbook brought up grief, loss, or something heavier than you expected, your doctor, a grief counselor, or the Eldercare Locator (eldercare.acl.gov, 1-800-677-1116, Monday to Friday 8 a.m. to 9 p.m. Eastern) can connect you with free local help, including your Area Agency on Aging. If you are thinking about harming yourself, call or text 988 (US) now. If someone is hurting, controlling or stealing from you or someone you know, contact your local Adult Protective Services, or 911 in an emergency.

Now go and make the call. Mars